in his vision. Take, for instance, *12th Fail*, which took three years to write and a year and a half of preparation before a 38-day shoot commenced.

Massey had heard some of the "folklore" around Chopra when he auditioned for the lead on Rajkumar Hirani's recommendation. "I've always clicked with oddballs," Massey says of Chopra. "He is a tough taskmaster and can bring you down to earth in an instant, no matter who you are. A lot of people cannot take what he says because they lack the ability to listen to the truth. But I see it as my breeding ground." Chopra doesn't care what people think of him. Perhaps that's what has kept him going for so long.

Chopra's own story of breaking into the industry is as inspirational as his *12th Fail* hero's. Growing up in Wazir Bagh in Srinagar, Chopra would hang around at Broadway cinema hoping to score a free ticket. He cites businessman Vijay Dhar, a Kashmiri Pandit like Chopra, for indulging his cinematic cravings. But getting into the film trade wasn't something his father approved of. 'He said, '*Bhookha mar jaayega* (you'll starve to death)'," Chopra recalls. Persistent, he scored a first class in economics from SP College and won a national scholarship of Rs 250 per month that came in handy to study filmmaking at FTII. The works of Jean-Luc Godard, Orson Welles' *Citizen Kane* and Federico Fellini's $8\frac{1}{2}$ would leave a vivid impression. Shah recalls Chopra as one of the few students who had no beard and looked more a student of acting and less of direction. "*Duniya ka bojh apne kandhon pe liye hue* [bearing the world's burden on his shoulders]... he was wise and profound and creative," he recalls.

By then, his batchmates knew he was going to be a disruptor in the film landscape. His diploma film, *Murder at Monkey Hill* (1976), would win the National Award for best experimental film. His second short, *An Encounter with Faces* (1978), would be nominated for an Oscar. His feature directorial debut, *Sazaye Maut* (1981), and *Khamosh* (1986), a clever critique of the Hindi film industry in the guise of a whodunit, made on shoestring budgets, didn't make money but pointed to his genius. It took *Parinda* (1989), cited as one of the finest in the gangster film genre, for it to be finally noticed and lauded. He brought down his mother, Shanti Devi, for its premiere but was unable to send her back to Srinagar due to the violence that erupted in the state against Kashmiri Pandits. The insurgency and its impact became the subject of two films he would go on to direct—*Mission Kashmir* (2000) and *Shikara* (2020).

Chopra's filmmaking career received a fillip when he turned a producer who enabled aspiring directors. *1942 A Love Story* would be the first film that showcased the talents of a certain Sanjay Leela Bhansali, credited for screenplay and associate director of songs. *Parineeta* (2005) marked the feature debut of renowned ad filmmaker Pradeep Sarkar and actress Vidya Balan. Chopra next collaborated with his editor Rajkumar Hirani and writer Abhijat Joshi for the Munna Bhai films. Hirani lauded Chopra's insistence "on getting it right before you hit the set". "He made us believe that make the film you want to make and not what others want you to make," says Hirani.

It's what Chopra continues to do. He loves reading Hindi and Urdu poetry and books on philosophy and films; also listening and singing along to S.D. Burman songs. His refuge is his house, which is three hours away from the city, and is named after the mohalla he grew up in. He himself refuses to grow up. "As adults, the tragedy is, our self-esteem comes from the bucks we have and the hits we get on the internet," he says. "What do kids want? They want to have fun." For Chopra, that fun comes from being frank—in life and in movies. ■



**I have always clicked with oddballs. He is a taskmaster and he will bring you down to earth in an instant, no matter who you are. A lot of people are not able to take what he says because they lack the quality to listen to the truth. But I see it as my breeding ground**

–VIKRANT MASSEY
*Actor who plays the lead in* 12th Fail



***Duniya ka bojh apne kandhon pe liye hue* [Carries the world's burden on his shoulders]... he was wise and profound and creative**

–NASEERUDDIN SHAH
*FTII Batchmate*